

State Agency Promising Practice

TOPIC:
Funding and
Service Contracting

Ohio: Using Funding to Improve Integrated Employment Services

By Jean Winsor and Racheal I Inegbedion

Project Background

The Impact of State Intellectual and Developmental Disabilities Agency Employment Contracting Methods and Service Payment Rates on Employment for Individuals with Intellectual and Developmental Disabilities (IDD) is a project of the Institute for Community Inclusion at the University of Massachusetts Boston. The goal of this project is to explore how state IDD agencies' contracting and payment methods supported the use of innovative employment services, access to assistive technology, or improvements in the employment services workforce to ensure access to high-quality employment services. To explore this topic, we have selected eight states whose IDD agency and/or Medicaid Authority developed and implemented financing strategies that reflect the factors of interest.

Introduction

Ohio's Employment First and Technology First policies work together to encourage the use of technology to improve employment outcomes for individuals with intellectual and developmental disabilities (IDD), particularly through its Medicaid Home and Community Based Services (HCBS) Waiver system. This stance, supported by executive orders and strategic planning since as early as 2011, emphasizes the importance of technology in enhancing the quality of life and independence for people with IDD.

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State Initiatives and Strategic Implementation

Financing and Policy Structures

Ohio is increasingly leaning toward the adoption of value-based payments within its Medicaid HCBS Waivers, reflecting a shift toward rewarding quality and outcomes rather than the volume of services delivered. This approach is evident in Ohio's Adult Day Support (ADS) Quality Pilot Project, funded by American Rescue Plan Act (ARPA) funds, which aims to enhance the quality of day program services through technology investments. The pilot project involves 99 community rehabilitation providers, each of whom was offered a grant of \$10,000 to make technological advancements to improve the efficiency and quality of their day habilitation program.

The state has been innovative in other ways, using ARPA and state general revenue funds to support technology use to improve services. An example is the Internet Assistance Project, which reimburses local level service planning agencies for wireless internet services for eligible service recipients, ensuring individuals can access the web and use their technology throughout their communities for integrated employment and day services.



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Technological Integration and Service Expansion

Ohio recognized technology as a crucial element in supporting individuals with IDD early on. Ohio's journey toward integrating technology in IDD services began with an executive order designating Ohio as a "Technology First" state, which laid the groundwork for a strategic, state-wide embrace of technological solutions across service delivery models. Ohio prioritizes technological solutions for improving service delivery, from telehealth to remote supports. The state's individual service plan incorporates technology into its discovery and assessment processes to emphasize the strategy to support all individuals with IDD. Ohio has also introduced assistive technology services under its Medicaid HBCS Waiver programs, demonstrating a proactive approach to employing technology in residential settings.

Technology Expertise and Assessments

Ohio uses contracts with technology experts to ensure that teams have access to necessary expertise. This approach allows for a thorough assessment of individuals' needs and the identification of appropriate technological solutions, thereby facilitating a more tailored and effective use of technology to improve the state's service delivery. State staff emphasized the importance of using technology experts for people with IDD to understand the needs of the users before implementing technology solutions. Staff also suggested that technology may be misperceived as complex if it is viewed as a novelty and not as a regular part of the employment process.

Despite these advancements, Ohio faces challenges in achieving full buy-in for service expansion. One challenge is the lack of understanding and familiarity among potential users and their families. State staff noted that users and their families had a difficult time trusting that the technology would work, and that using technology was an unfamiliar way of interacting with support staff. To address this, Ohio offers technology-related technical assistance and training as well as a technology library, and emphasizes trial and error in technology adoption, ensuring that services are tailored to meet individual needs effectively.

The state's Tech Ambassador Program uses a peer-to-peer model to enhance awareness of the benefits of technology for people with IDD. This program enlists individuals with disabilities who use technology in different ways to share their experiences and advocate for the benefits of incorporating technology in everyday life. This peer-led approach helps demystify technology for others in the IDD community, fostering a more supportive environment for technology adoption. Over time, the program has evolved and now includes family mentors and direct support professionals who relay their experiences and expertise around how technology has improved the way they support people.

Ohio's strategic plan has expanded to include dedicated staff resources for its technology team, highlighting the growing importance of technology in service delivery. The focus on technology has been further strengthened by the shift from a single person managing the technology team in the Medicaid division to its current location in the Policy division. The Policy division has also created a quality and innovation team to oversee multiple initiatives.

The state emphasizes the need for ongoing training and expertise in technology to keep pace with advancements and regulatory requirements. The state has also emphasized training and supporting all levels of the service delivery system. This includes enhancing the skills of case managers and connecting them with technology experts who can identify the most suitable technological solutions for individuals' needs. These efforts are complemented by the establishment of regional technology hubs across the state, which provide training and experimentation spaces for technology.

Impact

The inclusion of assistive technology and remote services within Ohio's Medicaid Waivers has enhanced the state's ability to provide individuals with IDD access to technology to achieve their goals for employment and community living. However, the state knew it needed to address secondary barriers to using technology if it wanted people with IDD to use these services widely.

By addressing the challenges individuals with IDD may have accessing the internet, Ohio has enabled more people to use technology and receive services directly in their community with minimal obvious support from paid professionals. This has increased independence and opportunities for community belonging for individuals with IDD. The Tech Ambassador Program further supports this by providing real-time guidance and mentoring by people with IDD for people with IDD to use technology to further their goals.

Ohio has also developed two Ohio Tech Goals around 1) increasing the use of remote support services and 2) increasing access to all technology-related supports (including assistive technology and virtual support). In 2024, the number of people using remote support services increased 39%.

Challenges, Opportunities, and Future Directions

Ohio is focused on making technology a regular part of conversations about services. Questions about technology are embedded in Ohio's individualized plans for services. Ohio's IDD agency is actively engaged in the use of performance measures at multiple levels of implementation to understand the ongoing impact of technology. Additionally, efforts continue to expand to broaden internet access and develop regional technology hubs. These hubs will offer training and space for experimentation with technology. This initiative aims to build confidence and competence among users and providers, promoting a more widespread and effective use of technology in supporting individuals with IDD.

Conclusion

Ohio's long-term commitment to integrating technology into IDD services reflects a forward-thinking approach to enhancing independence, efficiency, and quality of life for individuals with disabilities. Through strategic planning, collaborative efforts, and targeted funding of innovative programs, Ohio is setting a precedent for how technology can be harnessed to improve service delivery and outcomes for the IDD community. As the state continues to navigate challenges and explore new opportunities, its experience offers valuable insights for other states and stakeholders aiming to leverage technology.



The contents of this report were developed under a grant from the National Institute on Disability, Independent Living, and Rehabilitation Research (NIDILRR grant #90IFRE0058). NIDILRR is a Center within the Administration for Community Living (ACL), Department of Health and Human Services (HHS). The contents of this report do not necessarily represent the policy of NIDILRR, ACL, or HHS, and you should not assume endorsement by the Federal Government.

Suggested citation: Winsor, J., & Inegbedion, R.I. (2025). Ohio: Using Funding to Improve Integrated Employment Services [State Agency Promising Practice Series]. University of Massachusetts Boston, Institute for Community Inclusion.

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Year of publication: 2025